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Unforgivably Unforgettable: *Mysterious Skin*'s Trauma-Informed Masculinities

Gregg Araki's *Mysterious Skin* (2004), a coming-of-age film based on Scott Heim's 1995 novel of the same name, follows the development and lives of two childhood friends, Brian, and Neil. Before the events of the film, both boys are sexually abused by their nameless Little League baseball coach in Wichita, Kansas, and respond to this experience in vastly different ways – Neil moves to New York and becomes an openly homosexual male prostitute, while Brian becomes agoraphobic and retreats into a fantasy of alien abduction (Araki, 2004). Considered an ambitious film for its "genuine" portrayal of the "scars left behind by childhood sexual abuse" by film critic Roger Ebert, but also controversial enough in its portrayal of abuse and homosexual relationships to garner an NC-17 rating by the Motion Pictures Association of America (MPAA), the film provides a complex look at the long-lasting effects of trauma and its influence on an individual's behaviors and identity, with particular attention paid to masculinity and the influence of older men on boys' developments (Ebert, 2004; MPAA, 2004).

Neil and Brian process their trauma in different ways, which is apparent within the first two minutes. Opening with Joseph Gordon-Levitt's whispered narration, later revealed to be a teenage Neil, we hear a confession: "the moment I was eight years old, five hours disappeared from my life" (Araki, 2004). An incredibly out-of-focus shot is shown, with a white background and fuzzy blobs falling from the sky. There is sad, intense, music playing as the shot focuses on pieces of cereal falling in front of two smiling children. Immediately after, the scene switches to one of the boys, revealed to be a young Brian, found crying in a dark closet by his older sister,

similarly having no memory of the previous five hours. He remembers being at Little League, having a bloody nose, and eventually being found by his sister, but does not remember anything within those five hours. The film has a non-linear narrative, as Brian and Neil narrate their parallel stories, starting with the summer that they were abused and ending with their reunion as teenagers.

When Brian is found, he is taken to the living room and given a napkin to stop the nosebleed, and sits in the living room playing when his mother arrives. Brian's childhood home is tidy, and looks like it should be a comfortable family home but is also shown with slightly muted colors as if there is a layer of dust on everything. The living room is all yellow, but it looks soft and faded rather than bright. When Brian's mother is bathing him, the entire bathroom is pink and white, yet there is grime shown in the tiles and rust in the tub and spigot. This feeling of not being quite clean is a visual metaphor for Brian's childhood imagination of the assault, and adds to the impression of something being off with Brian. Since the viewer is already aware that he is a survivor, this environment reflects his lingering need to wash an experience off the skin that can't be shed.

Brian's family displays intense representations of femininity and masculinity. His father is shown as overworked, so much so that he forgot to pick his son up from Little League the day he initially started to lose track of time and have nose bleeds. When Brian's mother arrives home she immediately starts to dote over her "little boy," while her husband behaves nonchalantly and implies that his son just needs to "man up" and not be babied by his mother (Araki, 2004). She insists on letting Brian quit baseball, against the father's wishes, without knowing that she is saving him from continued abuse. This plays out in greater, more problematic ways, as Brian begins exhibiting trauma responses of blackouts, fainting, and more nosebleeds – his father is

shown yelling at and hitting him, demanding more "masculine" behavior from his son, while his mother seems to be more understanding and supportive. It is later discovered that Brian's parents are divorced, and his father is no longer a part of his life, which liberates Brian from a negative, neglectful influence on his masculinity.

As a teen, Brian is shown to be intelligent yet reclusive, and obsessed with UFOs, determining that he was abducted by aliens for those five hours in his youth. Since he was a child, and not entirely aware of the abuse, the alien abduction narrative is a logical reason for his hours spent missing, and shows how he uses his imagination to cope. There is a thread of blue light that is attached to all his memories of being abducted by aliens. He even remembers looking out the living room window and seeing the blue lights "coming out of the trees" (Araki, 2004). When the family is on the roof, the same blue lights radiate from a weather balloon flying above their home, which Brian claims is a "UFO." This solidifies Brian's coping fantasy as "real," and gives him a logical explanation for the experience that the people he confided in can experience as well.

Throughout Brian's story, there is continued usage of the color blue as he continues to learn more about what happened to him when he was eight years old. In his search for answers, he believes to have been abducted with him. He ends up "befriending" Neil's friend Eric, a coded queer relationship as Eric's kindness provides Brian with a sense of belonging and acceptance from another male for the first time in his life. Eric affectionately nicknames Brian "alien-boy," due to his quirks, and writes to Neil about him and his alien abduction stories (Araki, 2004). Eric is the catalyst for both Brian's eventual knowledge of his childhood abuse and his reconciliation with his old friend. It is only after this friendship begins that Brian's memories of being abducted by aliens begin to have the truth bleed through. Aside from Eric's

dyed hair reminding him of the lights, Brian begins to draw aliens wearing blue shorts and baseball caps – the same color as the Little League team's uniforms (Araki, 2004). The blue lights seen in Brian's memories are the same blue lights that are used at the end of the film as both boys return to the home that Coach once lived in, and where they learn the truth about what happened in their childhood. The usage of blue lights and abduction memories throughout Brian's coming of age shows the alienation that survivors of pedophilia will often experience, as they feel like no one understands their changes.

Neil is introduced as a polar opposite to Brian despite being his childhood friend, as he is very aware of his sexuality. When he watches his mother and stepfather having sex through his bedroom window, Neil ejaculates for the first time, and very shockingly says "I can't wait to show Coach" (Araki, 2004). This is the first time that pedophilia is mentioned or implied within the film, but it is notably lighthearted compared to the rest of the mentions since Neil is seen smiling. Neil goes on to explain that he always knew that he liked men, but that he "didn't know what to do" with his feelings, solidifying his awareness that he never really fit gendered expectations of "men." Since his biological father is deceased, and his stepfather is neglectful of him – choosing to sign him up for Little League so that he and his mom could "fuck without the little creep around" – Neil is in desperate need of a father figure (Araki, 2004).When he joins Little League, he immediately idolizes his coach as a symbol of masculinity, and the coach quickly made Neil feel special and treated him like the star player, including taking him to his home when his mom was working late and his stepfather was drunk. The coach's home is set up for children – he has a living room filled with expensive toys that most parents couldn't afford, as well as an Atari system and multiple arcade cabinets, which the teenage Brian remarks as looking "like the Sears Christmas catalog" (Araki, 2004). It was where the boys wanted to be,

and the coach took advantage of both Neil and – as it is revealed later – Brian having a lack of parental support that day to abuse them, making the home seem welcoming.

The story circles back and shows the start of the intro scene with cereal falling from the sky. As the boys and their coach sit down at the kitchen table, Neil spills some cereal, prompting the coach to pour cereal over them all to make light of the situation. He lays the boys down on the cereal and starts to touch their "junk" (as Neil says) and kiss them, and tells them that it is "never wrong" for someone to treat them this way. He says that they should never tell anyone about the situation, as "you liked it, it's okay that you liked it, and everything will be okay" (Araki, 2004). The older Neil recalls looking at the ceiling and describing it as a "shattered kaleidoscope," and that "the taste of Coach seared my mouth." This is in direct competition with the coach's language, which he used to "reinforce" that the boys – especially Neil – liked the encounter. The early moments, where the Little Leaguers were treated as "friends" and the coach acted like a healthy male influence, were happier, reflecting the coach's feelings as an abuser, while the adult Neil's narration and realization represent the aftermath. It is not uncommon for pedophiles to rationalize their behavior by convincing the child that they enjoyed the experience, and the "shattered" floor represents the moment of the boys' innocence being broken, and the way that this trauma influences them (Hart, 36). As both victims were already neglected or psychologically abused by males in their home lives, the abusive coach made it seem like he was looking out for them in a "friendly" way by the abuse, a common tactic for pedophiles preying on vulnerable children.

In the future, the teenage Neil drops out of school and deals with this trauma by becoming a male prostitute. Upon leaving Wichita with his friend Wendy, he takes pride in being paid for sex in New York. Throughout the film, Neil has three distinct experiences as a prostitute

that eventually help him come to terms with the fact that he was abused as a child. The first is with an older man who acts nice but does not realize that Neil is a minor. The man rejects Neil's offer once he states his age, but offers him snacks from his van and gives him advice on sexual health. The second interaction is a reverse of the first, as Neil becomes sexually involved with a man slightly older than him in a hotel room. The man does not possess any condoms, however, and Neil has unprotected anal sex for the first time. While penetrating the man, Neil's face turns blank and his eyes glass over, as if he is chasing an old feeling – this makes him think about his former coach and ejaculate immediately. This is the first time it appears that Neil is chasing a feeling that he believes he had when he was a child, and this feeling gives him a unique sense of power and control that he did not have at the start. Coming to terms with his sexuality made Neil significantly more confident, and his sex work is an expression of that confidence.

The third and final interaction is a return to the violent displays of masculinity from the film's beginning, coupled with internalized homophobia. Neil is taken to an older man's apartment, forced to do cocaine, and then raped anally. The man calls Neil a "slut" and "whore," and tells him that "all [he's] good for is fucking." Neil (Araki, 2004). When Neil tries to leave through the bathroom, the man breaks in and hits him with a shampoo bottle, knocking him unconscious and sexually assaulting him after. Neil is then discarded onto the front lawn of the man's apartment and left to find his way home, bloody, in pain, and in shock. Immediately after, Neil is back in his apartment with Wendy, explains that this is the first sexual situation that has ever made him feel "bad," and reveals his past sexual experience – he believes that he "knows Coach loved [him]" and that it "felt like true love" (Araki, 2004). This conversation explains how Neil uses sex with strangers to chase a false feeling he was manipulated into having by his abuser. Wendy suggests that he may have been abused and manipulated, which makes Neil

return to Wichita, since now that he is not able to use sex to run towards, or even after, this past experience, he needs to face the truth.

When Neil returns to Wichita, Eric reintroduces him to Brian, who it turns out Neil has been having dreams of. After they reconcile, he drives Brian to the home that was once their coach's house – it is decorated with blue Christmas lights, which threaded Brian's alien memories and reminds Neil of the truth. When Neil and Brian break in through the window, they discover that there is an "American nuclear family," in Brian's words, living there (Araki, 2004). The boys describe what the home looked like when their coach lived there, and acknowledged that he used the toys and games to make the abuse seem "fun" and comfortable. For the first time, Neil and Brian are the same, as they both speak as victims, and Brian learns the truth from Neil. The camera pans away upon their hug, leading to a tender moment when the two boys acknowledge their trauma.

Although the boys have not talked since their childhood, their narrations express similar feelings in very different ways, and their "alternative" masculinities are connected through their trauma and assault. Brian is constantly told to "be a man" by other men in his life, showing rampant toxic masculinity in his environment and a negative effect on his masculinity as a result of the trauma, which is adjacent to Neil's feeling powerless due to the cycle of abuse he faces to re-enter the past. Dealing with their trauma helps them become more in touch with their feelings and able to reject gendered expectations of "men," and their acknowledging of being queer, whether directly like Neil or indirectly like Brian, liberates them from abuses past and present. Eric is an important part of their lives – and identities – as well, as he not only reunites them but encourages them to accept the truth, and he shows that they both need positive people in their lives, and how much they are impacted by their trauma.

Historically, gay, and lesbian movies were placed in a bucketed category of "special interest" films, in both libraries and film registries, due to the genre being perceived as too small to have its category (Wuest, 2018). *Mysterious Skin* belongs within a variety of genres – being a coming-of-age story, an erotic film, a queer film, and still a "special interest" for its "courageous" tackling of pedophilia and its effects (Ebert, 2004). Araki made bold storytelling choices when filming and directing *Mysterious Skin*, which creates a unique story about pedophilia through the eyes of the survivors instead of the perpetrator, and showing a sliding scale of masculinity informed by the trauma (Hart, 2016). By having the main characters tell their own stories, the audience is only hearing their perspective of the experiences, not the interpretations of outsiders like in most films, which can help viewers feel more sympathy to real-world victims of pedophilia.

Works Cited

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